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Additional Rules & Supplementary Material

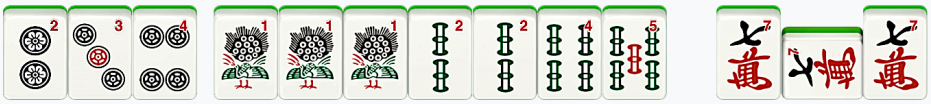
Tenpai—Readdressed

The formal definition of tenpai differs slightly from the one given earlier. More precisely:

A hand is in tenpai if it is one tile away from forming a valid hand—defined as a hand with four sets and a pair, seven distinct pairs, or the Thirteen Orphans yaku.

Under this definition, a hand does not need to be one tile away from winning; it only needs to be one tile away from a valid hand.

For example, consider the following hand:



This hand does not satisfy any yaku, so it is not one tile away from winning. However, it has three sets and a pair already formed, with 45-sou as the incomplete set. Both 3-sou and 6-sou complete 45-sou as a sequence, so the hand is one tile away from forming a fourth set. The hand is thus one tile away from a valid four-sets-and-a-pair hand and is considered tenpai under the formal definition.

Tenpai for a hand with no yaku is referred to as *yakuless tenpai* or *keishiki (shape) tenpai*. Though it cannot win normally, it still counts for a player's tenpai status at the end of an exhaustive draw.

Note: A hand is still considered tenpai even if all of its waiting tiles are visible among the discards and called sets. For example, the following hand is tenpai even if all three other copies of 9-pin have already been discarded by the other players:

However, at least one tile must exist that could complete the hand to a valid structure. A valid hand cannot contain five of the same tile, so a hand containing four copies of the same tile cannot wait on the fifth copy. For example, the hand below has 4 sets and is waiting on a 5th copy of 9-man, which does not exist, so it is not tenpai.

Furiten (continued)

Besides discard furiten, there are two additional forms: temporary furiten and permanent furiten.

- Temporary furiten occurs when a player declines to call ron on a winning discard. The player may not call ron until after their next discard, though may still win by tsumo.

  Example: Suppose a player is waiting on 8-sou. If an opponent discards 8-sou and the player declines to call ron, they enter temporary furiten. Until their next discard, they may not call ron on any discarded 8-sou, but they may still win by drawing 8-sou themselves.

- Permanent furiten occurs when a player who has declared riichi fails to claim a winning discard. The player becomes furiten for the remainder of the hand and may only win by tsumo.

Both forms of furiten carry strategic implications, influencing which tiles a player chooses to discard to avoid dealing into other players' hands.

Example: Temporary Furiten

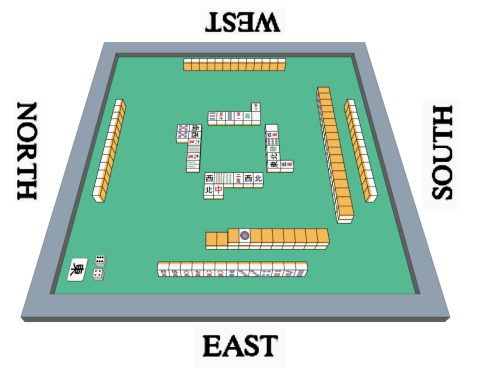
Suppose East, South, West, and North are seated at the table as shown. North discards 3-man and West does not claim it for a win. It follows that either 3-man was not a winning tile for West, or West chose to decline ron. If West declined to call ron, they enter temporary furiten and cannot call ron until after their next discard. In either case, if East were to now discard 3-man, West would not be able to claim it for a win.

By the same reasoning, if South also does not claim 3-man for a win, East may discard 3-man without risk of dealing into South's hand.

North also cannot win off 3-man because of discard furiten.

Therefore, if both West and South do not claim 3-man for a win, East may safely discard 3-man — no player can win on it.

In general, the most recently discarded tile is safe to discard against all players.



Example: Permanent Furiten

In another scenario, suppose South has just declared riichi. If West discards 1-pin and South does not claim it for a win, either South declined to call ron or 1-pin was not their winning tile. If South declined to call ron, they enter permanent furiten and may not call ron on any discard for the remainder of the hand. In either case, both North and East may now discard 1-pin come their turn without risk of dealing into South's riichi hand.

More generally, any discard not claimed by a player in riichi is safe against that player. The complete set of tiles safe against a player includes tiles in that player's discard pile — due to discard furiten — as well as tiles they pass up after declaring riichi. These safe tiles are called *genbutsu* to that player.

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Why Does Furiten Exist?

The rule of furiten exists in part to prevent players from targeting a specific opponent for payment. In Riichi mahjong, the player who discards the winning tile bears full responsibility for paying the value of the hand. Without furiten, a malicious player could attempt to exploit this by intentionally forming valuable hands, discarding their own winning tiles when drawn, and waiting for a chosen opponent to discard the same tile instead.

Likewise, a player could decline to call ron on other opponents and instead wait specifically for the targeted player to deal in. Furiten prevents both forms of selective targeting by disallowing wins on any tile a player has previously discarded and by causing a player to enter furiten if they passed on a potential winning tile, ensuring that a player cannot cherry-pick whose discard gives them the win.

Importantly, furiten does not prevent a player from winning by tsumo, since self-drawn wins remain permitted even while in furiten. Because a tsumo win spreads payment among the opponents rather than assigning it to a single discarder, it reinforces the rule's function of preventing selective targeting and promoting equitable outcomes.

At the same time, furiten enables defensive play, increasing the game's strategic depth. Because a player cannot win by ron on tiles in their own discard pile, and because tiles they decline to claim after declaring riichi become *genbuts*u, other players can identify specific tiles that are safe to discard. This information allows players to plan their discards more carefully, creating opportunities to press for points while reducing the risk of dealing into an opponent's hand. For example, if a player suspects another may be in tenpai, or if an opponent has declared riichi, they can discard tiles that are genbutsu to that player to maintain a wait on a high-value hand or to attempt a strategic push for riichi themselves. As a result, furiten provides players with defensive resources, making the game more interactive and strategic.

Finally, furiten furthers the depth of the considerations made when forming a hand, encouraging players to think about how their discards affect future winning eligibility. If a player discards 2-man early in the hand, then they should be cognizant that drawing 1-man, 2-man, 3-man, or 4-man and keeping any in the hand runs the risk of furiten later. Otherwise, a player could find themselves in discard furiten and not know it.

For example, suppose a player has discarded 2-man early in the hand. Suppose the player later draws 4-man and decides to keep it for the remainder of the hand. Much later, the player forms a hand that is one tile away from tenpai. If they then draw 3-man, forget about the previously discarded 2-man, and declare riichi, they may fail to realize that they are in discard furiten and therefore cannot call ron.

However, if the player had kept in mind that 2-man remained in their discard pile, drew 3-man, and declared riichi as an intentional decision—after considering their standing in the game, their hand's expected value, and the existing score differentials at the table—and recognizing that they could still win by tsumo, then the declaration reflects deliberate strategic judgment rather than oversight.

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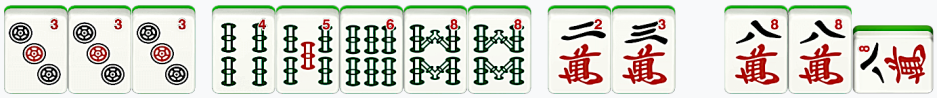
Discard Furiten—Readdressed

The formal definition of discard furiten is broader than the one given earlier. In general terms:

Discard furiten occurs if any tile in a player's discard pile completes a valid hand for that player.

This definition has a subtle but important consequence.

Suppose a player is in tenpai for all simples with the following hand:



The incomplete set is 23-man, and the only winning tile is 4-man.

4-man completes 23-man to form a sequence, producing a valid four-sets-and-a-pair hand. However, 1-man also completes 23-man as a sequence, thereby completing a valid hand — even though it would not produce a winning hand because no yaku would be satisfied.

Under the formal definition, this distinction does not matter. If 1-man is already in the player's discard pile, the player is in discard furiten, because a tile in their discard pile completes a valid hand.

As a result, the player may not call ron on a discarded 4-man until they change their wait to exclude 1-man (and any other tiles in their discard pile).

Under the simplified explanation given earlier — that discard furiten occurs only if a player's winning tile is in their discard pile — the player would not have been in furiten unless 4-man itself had been discarded.

The key takeaway is this:

If any tile in your discard pile completes your hand to a valid structure, you are in discard furiten — even if that tile would not have produced a winning yaku.

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Temporary Furiten—Readdressed

The precise definition of temporary furiten is more general than the one given before. Formally stated:

Temporary furiten occurs if an opponent's discard completes a valid hand for a player and the player does not claim it.

This definition has an important consequence.

Suppose a player is in tenpai with the following closed hand:

Their incomplete set is 78-sou, and their winning tiles are 6-sou (for all simples possibly with tsumo) and 9-sou (tsumo only).

Both 6-sou and 9-sou complete 78-sou as a sequence, producing a structurally valid hand (four sets and a pair). Therefore, if either tile is discarded and not claimed by the player, the player enters temporary furiten under the formal definition.

If the player declines to call ron on 6-sou, nothing changes from the simplified explanation: passing on a winning tile causes temporary furiten until their next discard.

The difference arises with 9-sou. Because 9-sou is a tsumo-only win, the player cannot legally call ron on it. Even so, the tile completes a valid hand structure. As a result, when an opponent discards 9-sou and the player must pass (because ron is not allowed), they nevertheless enter temporary furiten.

For example, if the opponent to their right discards 9-sou, the player must pass and enters temporary furiten. If another opponent then discards 6-sou before the player's next turn, the player may not call ron for all simples until after their next discard.

Under the simplified explanation given earlier — that temporary furiten occurs only when a player declines ron on a winning tile — the discard of 9-sou would not have caused furiten, since the tile could not legally be claimed by ron.

Under the formal definition, however, the 9-sou discard completed a valid hand structure for the player. Passing on it — even involuntarily — triggered temporary furiten.

Note on Robbing a Quad (Chankan):

Among standard competitive Riichi rulesets, a player who fails to claim a win by robbing a quad (chankan) becomes temporarily furiten.

Furthermore, if the tile used to upgrade a triplet to a quad completes a valid hand for a player — even if it does not provide a winning yaku — failing to claim it results in temporary furiten.

If a player has declared riichi and fails to rob the quad, they are permanently furiten for the remainder of the hand.

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Certain Hands Run the Risk of Furiten

Besides hands with 1–4 or 6–9 waits for all simples, hands involving a dual-pon wait — where one tile completes a yakuhai triplet and the other yields no yaku — are particularly susceptible to furiten, especially when the hand is open

For example, suppose a player is in tenpai for red dragon only, with the following hand:

The hand is waiting on either:

- Red dragon (to complete a yakuhai triplet and win), or
- 8-pin (which completes the structure but provides no yaku)

If an opponent discards 8-pin, it completes the hand's structure of four sets and a pair. Even though the hand cannot win on 8-pin, passing on it places the player into temporary furiten. The player may not call ron on a subsequently discarded red dragon until after their next discard.

If the player instead draws 8-pin themselves, the hand cannot win. If they then discard 8-pin, they enter discard furiten, since a tile in their discard pile now completes a valid hand. In this state, they cannot call ron on a red dragon unless they alter their wait to exclude 8-pin (and any other tiles in their discard pile).

The hands explored in the passages above are examples of hands in a state known as *atozuke* (backdoor waits or late yaku attachment), where the hand lacks a guaranteed yaku but can gain one upon receiving a specific winning tile.

As shown, hands in atozuke — particularly when opened — are especially vulnerable to furiten. However, if the hand has enough value, it is often worth it to risk atozuke.

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Liability Payment「責任払い」*Sekinin barai*

Sekinin barai, or the rule of *pao*, is a liability payment imposed when a player enables another player to complete a yaku or yakuman.

The rule is primarily applied to yakuman. In particular, a player is liable for payment if they discard the tile that completes the final triplet or quadruplet of the Big Three Dragons or Big Four Winds yakuman, after the other required triplets or quads have already been completed as called sets.

To illustrate liability under *sekinin barai* for a Big Three Dragons yakuman, consider the following example:

Suppose a player has already completed Red Dragon and Green Dragon as open triplets. An opponent discards a White Dragon tile, and the player calls Pon, completing the White Dragon triplet, thereby confirming the final triplet of the Big Three Dragons yakuman. If that discard did not already complete the hand, the discarding player becomes liable for payment.

Under *sekinin barai*, the liable player alone pays the full value of the yakuman if the winning player self-draws. If the winning player completes the hand on another opponent's discard, that opponent shares the payment equally with the liable player, but only the other opponent pays for any honba counters.

Note: *Sekinin barai* is a recognized but non-universal rule. It appears frequently in formal, competitive, and online rulesets but is often omitted in casual or beginner play.

Note: *Sekinin barai* is also commonly applied to the Four Quads yakuman, and occasionally to the After a Kan yaku (*rinshan kaihou*). In the latter case, *sekinin barai* is imposed when a player discards a tile that another player calls Kan on, and the Kan-declaring player wins with the dead wall draw, or any other dead wall draw before their next discard.

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Closed Kans During Riichi—Revisited

It was previously stated that a player who has declared riichi may declare a closed quad provided that the drawn tile matches a closed triplet and it does not change their waiting tiles. However, official rules add an additional condition to preserve the hand's structure: the three other tiles can only be interpreted as a triplet in the original riichi hand. This restriction exists to prevent declaring a closed quad when the three other tiles could serve multiple roles in different interpretations of the hand.

To see why this matters, consider a player who has declared riichi and is waiting on 7-man or 8-man with the following hand:

The player may not declare a closed quad of 6-man.

Although 666-man appears to be just a triplet, the three tiles can be interpreted differently. One interpretation of the hand uses:

- 66-man as the pair
- 999-man, 456-pin, and 111-sou as completed sets
- 68-sou as the incomplete set waiting on 7-man

In this interpretation, the three 6-man tiles are not strictly a triplet: two serve as the pair (66-man), and the third functions as part of a 678-man sequence when 7-man completes the hand. Because the three tiles to be used for the quad could be interpreted not just as a triplet, the closed quad is not permitted.

For the same reason, the player may also not declare a closed quad of 9-man.

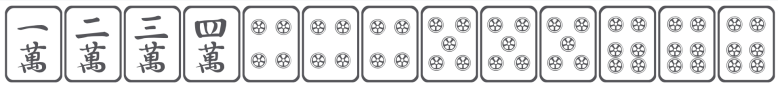
The hand can also be interpreted with:

- 99-man as the pair
- 666-man, 456-pin, and 111-sou as completed sets
- 89-man as the incomplete set waiting on 7-man

Here, the three 9-man tiles could function as a pair (99-man) plus a 9-man forming part of 789-man when 7-man completes the hand. Again, the three tiles to be used for the quad are not exclusively a triplet, so the quad is disallowed.

However, the player may declare a closed quad of 1-sou, since the three other tiles function exclusively as a triplet in every possible interpretation of the hand, and forming 1111-sou does not alter the wait.

For a final illustration, consider a player who declared riichi and is waiting on 1-man or 4-man with the following hand:



The player is not able to declare a closed quad of 4-pin, 5-pin, or 6-pin because the three triplets can be interpreted as three 456-pin sequences, even though this interpretation yields the lowest-scoring outcome, since Pure Double Sequence (1 han) scores less than Three Concealed Triplets (2 han).

Note: While tournament and competitive rules enforce this additional requirement for closed quads during riichi, many digital platforms and casual groups omit this restriction.

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Rule Variations

Although Japanese Riichi Mahjong has a widely recognized core ruleset, there is no single governing body that standardizes every rule. As a result, different clubs, house groups, competitive formats, and online platforms often adopt slightly different rule settings. Many of these optional rules are described using the terms *ari* (enabled) or *nashi* (disabled). For example, *kuikae ari* means swap calling is allowed, while *kuikae nashi* means it is not.

In addition to the variations already discussed in the guide, the following are further examples that may appear in different rulesets.

Open Tanyao (*Kuitan*)

Kuitan determines whether the yaku All Simples (*Tanyao*) may be scored with an open hand.

Kuitan ari — An open hand may score tanyao.
Kuitan nashi — Tanyao is only allowed for closed hands.

Most modern rulesets — including many online platforms and competitive environments — use *kuitan ari*, making open tanyao one of the most common low-value open hands in the game.

Dora Variations

Nearly all Riichi Mahjong games use dora indicators, which increase the value of certain tiles. However, several optional variations exist.

Five fives (akadora) — Whether to use the four red fives commonly included in many Japanese mahjong sets (two red 5-pin, one red 5-sou, and one red 5-man), to use one red five in each suit, or to omit them entirely.

Kandora and uradora — Whether additional dora indicators are revealed after each kan declaration (kandora), and whether hidden dora indicators are revealed after a riichi win (uradora).

Some tournament rulesets limit or remove certain dora types to reduce scoring volatility.

Ippatsu

Some competitive rulesets disable Ippatsu entirely. Removing Ippatsu reduces the reward for quick riichi wins and slightly lowers overall scoring.

Big Honba

In a few rulesets, honba counters increase the bonus payments awarded when consecutive dealer repeats or exhaustive draws occur. This variation is sometimes called big honba, where each honba adds a larger bonus than usual, such as 1,500 points instead of the standard 300.

Because these variations exist, it is always important to confirm the rules being used before beginning a game.

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Competitive Play

Because mahjong contains a significant element of chance, competitive play typically uses multiple games rather than relying on the result of a single game. Even highly skilled players can experience large swings in score due to the random distribution of tiles, the appearance of dora, or the timing of high-value hands. By playing several hanchan and combining the results, tournaments reduce the influence of short-term luck and allow player skill, decision-making, and consistency to have a greater impact on the final standings. This format is therefore considered a fairer way to determine rankings in organized play.

For example, in a simple league format, four players — A, B, C, and D — might play a four-hanchan match against each other. After each hanchan, the players' results are converted into tournament points, which are then added together to determine the final ranking.

Several additional scoring concepts are commonly used in competitive play.

Goal (Target Score)

Many rulesets define a target score, which is often 30,000 points. This value is commonly equal to the number of points each player begins with at the start of the game. The target score is used as a reference point for calculating tournament performance.

Score Delta

Instead of tracking large point totals, tournaments often use a value called the score delta to measure a player's performance in each game. After a hanchan ends, a player's final score is compared to the target score, and the difference is divided by 1,000.

A simplified version of the calculation is:

score delta = (final score − target score) ÷ 1,000

For example, if player A finishes the first hanchan with 41,300 points, their raw scoring performance would be:

(41,300 − 30,000) ÷ 1,000 = 11.3

This value represents the player's raw tournament performance for that game before placement bonuses are applied.

Uma (Placement Bonus or Penalty)

Uma is a placement bonus or penalty applied after a hanchan ends. Instead of ranking players solely by their raw score delta, additional points are awarded based on finishing position.

For example, a common uma setting might be:

- 1st place: +15
- 2nd place: +5
- 3rd place: −5
- 4th place: −15

Continuing the example above, if player A finished in 1st place, their total performance for that game would be:

11.3 (score delta) + 15 (uma) = 26.3

After several hanchan are played, the score deltas and uma values from each game are added together for each player to determine the overall standings.

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Tournament Penalties

Competitive play also introduces penalties that are rarely enforced in casual games. These penalties exist to maintain fairness and prevent illegal actions from influencing the outcome of the game.

Chombo

A chombo is a serious rules violation. In many tournament rulesets, a chombo results in a 20,000-point penalty applied to the offending player's tournament score after the game is finished, typically after uma has been applied.

Outside tournament settings, a chombo is often treated as a reverse mangan payment, where the offending player pays 4,000 points to East and 2,000 points to the other players. If the offending player is East, they instead pay 4,000 points to each of the other players.

Common causes of chombo include:

- Invalidly declaring a win and revealing the tiles
  - For example, declaring a win by discard while being in furiten, or
  - Declaring a win while not in tenpai or not waiting on the tile used to declare the win
- Declaring riichi while not actually in tenpai (usually determined at the time of a win or an exhaustive draw)
- Exposing too many tiles from the hand or wall (for example, knocking over seven or more tiles according to WRC 2025 rules)

When a chombo occurs, the current hand is typically aborted and redealt, no honba counter is added or removed, and any riichi sticks are returned to the players who placed them.

Dead Hands

Some mistakes are considered less severe and instead result in a dead hand (sometimes called *agari houki*). A dead hand is never considered tenpai and cannot make calls such as riichi, chii, pon, kan, ron, or tsumo for the remainder of the hand.

Common situations that may result in a dead hand include:

- Making an empty call, such as declaring ron when the tile does not complete the hand
- Having an incorrect number of tiles in the hand
- Exposing too many tiles from the hand or wall (three to six tiles according to WRC rules)
- Making an illegal draw or discard, such as taking a tile from the wrong wall, drawing out of turn, or discarding a tile not in hand

A dead hand continues to participate in the round by drawing and discarding tiles, but the player forfeits the ability to gain any points from that hand.

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As seen, some infractions may be treated as a dead hand or a chombo depending on their severity. For example, the WRC 2025 rules illustrate the distinction clearly:

- “12.3.4 Melds — If a player forms a group that is neither a valid sequence, triplet, nor quad, or declares a false concealed quad, they may correct it as long as no tiles have been discarded. Once a discard has occurred, the invalid group cannot be changed, and the player’s hand becomes a dead hand. If an invalid quad is discovered after a discard, the player instead receives a chombo penalty, as it interferes with replacement tiles and the maximum number of quads, preventing the game from continuing normally.”

This example highlights how tournament rules distinguish between minor mistakes, which result in a dead hand, and major violations, which trigger a chombo. By clearly defining these penalties, tournaments maintain fairness, ensure smooth gameplay, and prevent any player from gaining an unintended advantage.

Because competitive environments emphasize fairness and consistency, these penalties help maintain order and prevent players from gaining unintended advantages. For this reason, organized events always provide a written ruleset before play begins, and players are expected to review the rules carefully before participating.

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Recommended Ruleset for Casual Play

Core Rules

- East-only or East-South game.
- Red fives are used.
- Each player starts with 25,000 points.
- Multiple ron is allowed.
  - If multiple players win, all riichi bets from winning players are returned to them. Any remaining riichi bets from non-winning players, as well as carryover bets from previous hands, are collected by the winner who is first in turn order after the discarder.
- Call precedence: Tsumo > Ron > Pon & Kan > Chii (a delayed call is valid)
  - Ron is valid until the next player discards, or declares Kan or Tsumo
  - Pon & Kan are valid until the player calling Chii reveals tiles from their hand
- A*gari yame* and *tenpai yame* are allowed: The dealer may end the game if they declare a win or are in tenpai at the end of all last and they are leading in points.
- Kandora indicators are flipped immediately regardless of open/closed kan.
- Swap-calling (*kuikae*) is not allowed.

Riichi

- You may declare riichi provided there remains at least one tile left in the live wall.
- No riichi under 1,000 points.
- You may declare a closed kan during riichi if the drawn tile matches a closed triplet and it does not change your waiting tiles.

Liability Payment and Abortive Draws

- No liability payment *(sekinin barai)*.
- No abortive draws.
- Four quads can be made, but under no circumstances can a fifth be made.

Scoring

- No mangan rounding up (*kiriage mangan*).
- Counted yakuman (*kazoe yakuman*) enabled: 13 han or greater scores yakuman.
- Double yakuman enabled.
- Multiple yakuman are scored for hands having several yakuman yaku. This excludes counted yakuman.

Yaku and Minipoints

- Thirteen Orphans can be won by robbing a concealed quad.
- Nagashi Mangan enabled.
- A double wind pair is worth 4 fu.
- No local yaku.

Game End Conditions

- Busting: The game immediately ends if any player's score falls below zero.
- 30,000 point minimum to win by the end of all last:
  - In an East-only game, play continues into the South round until a player reaches at least 30,000 points. If no player reaches this score by South 4, the game ends.
  - In an East-South game, play continues into the West round until a player reaches at least 30,000 points. If no player reaches this score by West 4, the game ends.

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Recommended Ruleset for Competitive Play

Core Rules

- East-South game.
- No red fives.
- Each player starts with 30,000 points.
- Only one winner per hand is allowed.
  - In cases of multiple ron claims (double or triple ron), the first in turn order after the discarder collects the win (head bump / *atamahane*). The speed of the ron call is otherwise not considered.
- Call precedence: Tsumo > Ron (turn order) > first caller > Pon & Kan > Chii
  - Ron is valid until the next player draws.
  - In case of two players calling the same tile for a set:
    - If the calls are clearly apart, the first call takes precedence.
    - If it's unclear if calls are simultaneous or not, consider they are.
- No *agari yame* or *tenpai yame*: If East wins or is tenpai at the end of all last, a dealer repeat occurs regardless of the scores.
- Kandora indicators are flipped immediately regardless of open/closed kan.
- Swap-calling (*kuikae*) is not allowed.

Riichi

- You may declare riichi provided there remains at least one tile left in the live wall.
- Riichi is permitted even below 1,000 points.
- You may declare a closed kan during riichi if the drawn tile matches a closed triplet, it does not change your waiting tiles, and the three other tiles can only be interpreted as a triplet in the original riichi hand.

Liability Payment and Abortive Draws

- Liability payment (*sekinin barai*) applies for Big Three Dragons, Big Four Winds and Four Quads.
- In case of multiple yakuman, the liability only applies to the yakuman fed.
- No abortive draws.
- Four quads can be made, but under no circumstances can a fifth be made.

Scoring

- Mangan rounding (*kiriage mangan*) applies: 4 han 30 fu or 3 han 60 fu or higher score mangan.
- No counted yakuman (*kazoe yakuman*): 11 han or greater scores sanbaiman.
- No double yakuman.
- Multiple yakuman are scored for hands having several yakuman yaku. This excludes counted yakuman.

Yaku and Minipoints

- Blessing of Man (*Renhou*) is enabled and scores mangan.
- No Nagashi Mangan.
- You may not rob a closed quad to win Thirteen Orphans.
- A double wind pair is worth 2 fu.

Game End Conditions

- No bankruptcy: Play continues with negative scores.
- No West round: The game ends after South 4.

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_____ Ruleset

Core Rules

Riichi

Liability Payment and Abortive Draws

Scoring

Yaku and Minipoints

Game End Conditions

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